UK Data Service

Pioneers

of Qualitative Research

Karen Dunnell

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2017

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

UK Data Archive, University of Essex, Colchester. November 2018

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Karen Dunnell

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

31 October 2017

1: The Science Hierarchy at School

Why did you decide, you chose science subjects, why did you decide on that?

Because I was very good at them. I was good at them. They were my best subjects. Also, at that time, I wanted to be a doctor. We had the most incredible science teachers. I think there were nine of us who went into the sixth form to do First MB - chemistry, physics and biology, and, of course, we had to do extra maths for the physics, and we had to do Use of English so that we could write. That was as joke, because I could write anyway! And then it became quite obvious, and they were pretty clear about it, that there was absolutely no point in most of us applying to do medicine, because there wouldn't be a hope of us getting in. Basically they let two, two of these nine girls got into Medical School, they were both the daughters of doctors – the only ones who were daughters of doctors – and one of them went off straight away when we did our 'A' Levels, and the other one failed her 'A' Levels, and then went to the Royal College of Music. She later had to re-sit. She was an amazing singer and flautist, who later became a maths teacher, funnily enough. But anyway, the rest of us were persuaded, well in those days, I think UCAS had only just been invented, and you couldn't do anything without their approval. (p. 8)

Had you already got an ability with maths, would you say?

'

Yes, yes. I mean I was okay at maths. I didn't get an 'A', but then I never got 'As' for anything. Nowadays, everybody who is anyone has to get 'As' for everything, [but] I never got any 'As'. Well, I probably got a couple. But no, I could do maths. I wouldn't have wanted to do 'A' Level maths, but in order to do physics and chemistry we had to do this thing called "extra maths for scientists", so the burden of school was incredible. I mean, compared to the people who were doing, like, English, history and French, we never had any free periods at all. It was really hard work, and we spent hours doing practicals, which I'm not sure they do

now. It was really really hard doing those subjects. (pp. 10-11)

Well, they were very good teachers… I mean, the physics teacher we used to torment rather. But I had this wonderful chemistry teacher, who was also my form mistress in the sixth form, she was the one who sort of had a crush on me. She was very very determined that I was going to follow in her footsteps and become a scientist and all that stuff. So they were all spinsters, they all lived in couples and drove their Morris Minors. It was very boring actually. Really boring! (p. 10)_

2: Friendship with Another Family and its Influence

I will tell you, the other important thing about my teenage years was that I met this family, through my mother actually, who became a tremendous intellectual and political influence on me. She was like my surrogate mother actually, and I spent a lot of time with this family. I'd already, when I met them when I was about 13, started serious reading. I'd always been a bookworm, from the age of four, but then I started reading, all sorts of - I can't even remember. But I remember beginning to read things which made me understand why my mother was so uncomfortable on this little council estate, and why she kept up with her tablecloths and her high heels and her little suits and all that. Because she was amazing.

So would that be from novels, or social research?

It would have been from novels, largely. So I began to understand about class and all of that.

Then this new family [Pat and George Seddon] arrived in our village. They lived in a corner, in a huge house, which I knew very well because I used to walk past it every day to go to my first primary school. He was an *Observer* journalist, and she was a teacher who landed up in my mother's school. And they had a daughter who came to my school, except she never cycled to the bus like I did, her mum took her, because her father went up to London every day, so she did a round and then drove to school. They had an older son who was at Bedales.

So my mother sent me up there on some errand – she said she'd lend Pat something – and so I went up there… I just became really really friendly – I was never very friendly with the daughter who was in the year below me, in my sister's year – but I became very very

friendly. It was probably a bit weird, with the mother. Because her daughter was also a total bookworm, but to such a point that she wouldn't move or do anything. So I spent a lot of time with them. And then I got to know the father, who was a wonderful exotic journalist, but actually was very very interesting, because he'd been a Conscientious Objector.

And they voted – they were Liberals! Golly, I'd never even heard of them! And I just became very involved in their family. I'd be up there for supper twice a week probably, and would spend a lot of time with them. And listened to them talking, and joined in, and read their books, and all of that. Then, of course, the thing that really – and I don't know how much it was them, or how much because my mother was also an avid reader – but all those amazing books came out, like *The Loneliness of the Long Distance Runner* and *The Room at the Top*, all those kind of working-class novelists, well, they weren't really, but they wrote about it, came out, and I just embraced it, and it was amazing! And then, I don't know, somehow I became very Left-wing. (pp. 8-10)

I had lunch last week with two of these other girls that went off to university to do things like physiology, then became doctors, went on to Medical School, and one of them's been in Australia for many years, but I had lunch with her the other week, because she was back, her sister lives near me, and she said to me, “Oh, you know, you were always so political, and Left-wing, and it was amazing.” Because her father was a plumber, so she actually understood it from a different point of view.,, So they were quite influential. (pp. 9-10)

3: The Entrance Interview for Bedford College

So I did the entrance exam, and then I got invited to an interview, and I had two interviews, one after the other, and they told me to go and sit down, back down outside. I had no idea. The only thing I remember from my school about - we had a chat with the Headmistress about interviews, and all I remember about this talk was her saying, “Don't wear a hat unless you're really comfortable in it”. I mean, I was, at that point, a 17 year old beatnik, to be honest with you! Well, I had my hair down here, and it was quite long, I mean, it wasn't allowed to be very long, but it was as long as I could get away with, and I just wore a lot of black and dingy colours and, yes, I thought I was the bees knees, to be honest! So I went to this interview, and as for the idea of wearing a hat, I thought she was bonkers, this woman! But anyway, they came out after a couple of minutes and called me back in, and said to me,

"We're going to give you a place, but don't tell anybody until you get the letter". And I just probably jumped up and down on the spot…

Do you think, in the interview, they got you arguing, or talking about things, was that it, really?

Yes. I mean, one of them asked me about a book that I'd read that had been interesting or had an impact on me. I'd just read this book called, *The Psychology of Sex*, which was actually written by a man, but was actually very very interesting because it was partly biological - of course, I was into it, so I was able to talk about that. They asked me about what I thought caused teenage pregnancy and all of that. They asked me why I'd chosen to do it, and God knows what I said, but I can remember it being very very upbeat. One of them was with two people – a man and a woman – I remember getting very very engaged. I mean, I was actually very well-read, I was much better read than the girls who were doing English and history, because that's what I did – I read. I read probably every modern novel, I kept up, and I'm still a bit like that. I'm less obsessional about it now, but I was reading all the latest books. Yes, so it wasn't difficult at all. No. So it was absolutely amazingly liberating. (p. 12)

4a: The Queen of Wang: Technology at the School of Hygiene

This was in the days when we did everything on a slide rule, and with a counter-sorter, and we had punch-cards, and we acquired a little programmable calculator thing, and it had a different kind of punch-card which you had to punch yourself, and I was the person who translated, you know, how to do complex chi-squares and regressions on to this card, and tested it, and made this little machine – it was called a "Wang", so I was the "Queen of the Wang!" And, anyway, look, I got this job, it was £1000 a year or something, and I just thought it was just heaven. I could do work, I could see the point of it. (p. 18)

4b

The technology was a nightmare. Well, Hospital Episodes statistics had its own antiquated system, because it's all historical, and Death Statistics had its own antiquated system. Then the General Practice Survey was re-invented every ten years. Everything was running on

different platforms, the staff weren't interchangeable, and all this went on in our office near Southampton. The technology was all there. So we had this enormous project of trying to move everything on to a standard data management system. I don't think it ever worked, and it caused enormous stress, and you were very reliant on companies, you put out a tender to get a company to work with you on re-configuring all this stuff, and then, of course, you had the terrible job of specifying of what it was you wanted, and then they were always really difficult to work with. I still don't think it's sorted. In fact, when we did the 2011 Census, that was all just put out to tender, and just done separately, because it was such a nightmare. So the technology was very very complicated – that side of it…

But anyway, it was a very exciting time then because what we were trying to do was to routinise, I suppose, the collection and the presentation of the basic stats., and to use our professional energy on writing about them – analysing, and writing about them. (p. 52)

4c

So all this attempt to make it all more coherent and so on, involves not only the statistical data themselves, but also all of the side processes, but it's on-going. you never really get there.

Well, for example, we had, because of the way that the survey system - and this was something I knew about in great detail - came about, we had a General Household Survey, which went out to thousands of households every year, we had a Labour Force Survey which went out to a different thousands of households, we had a Family Expenditure which went out to thousands of households every year, they all asked almost identical classificatory questions, okay? So one of the things was, and this was in what was just one part of the office, "Can we bring all that together, and just have one large sample, and have one chunk of the sample doing Labour Force, one doing Household, de-der-di-de-der. Well, you know, it was, we were on our way. And it failed partly because all the technology was different, because the Labour Force had been started off by the Department of Employment, so it had its own computer system, its own weighting system, because all these surveys are weighted up to produce actual numbers. So when you get that thing, there are, you know, 2,587,999 people unemployed, you know, it's an estimate based on a weighting, a grossing, a weighting and grossing. They all had different, so it was going to involve huge changes to all these national statistics which are pored over across government. But anyway, they now have this

thing called the Annual Population Survey, I think, which has incorporated most of it, so it's getting there. But these things take a very long time. (pp. 59)

5: Coffee Breaks as Seminars: The Institute of Community Studies

Peter [Willmott] was always my favourite, because we'd talk about work, we'd talk about what was going on in the outside world. These coffee breaks were like fantastic seminars, actually. But then we would also talk about books and films, and getting married, and all of that – anything, you could talk to them about. And Peter Marris was in and out, because he was, I think he had some appointment in America, but they were all doing these interview-based studies, so we talked about that all the time, you know, and how it all inter-related. Ann had people doing work on hospitals, chiropody, family planning – that's how I got into family planning, that was the study I worked on as her research assistant. (p. 19)

6: Developing Statistics on Family Formation

Going back to family formation. What do you think the most interesting unexpected findings were from that?

Oh, really being able to say, for the first time, to actually put some figures on cohabitation, marriage, separation, divorce, remarriage, you know, the whole thing. I think social research up until then had very much been a kind of snapshot. So it was a very early example of longitudinal survey research to be able to get a history, and to be able to analyse it by doing cohort analysis, rather than just what was happening to people in a cross-sectional way, So I think actually putting cohabitation, and what had happened to me really in my life, you know, this kind of serial relationships, being able to actually describe it, I think for the first time. (p. 39)

7: On Quantitative and Qualitative Research

[At the Institute of Community Studies] their standard methodology has still not changed. [Ann Cartwright] was trained at the Government Social Survey, which I eventually went on to work for. So you did a proper sample of areas, and then you took a sample within the area, and then you went round and recruited interviewers, selected them, trained them, supervised them, and that's what we did, I did.

So you didn't do many of the interviews yourself?

No, I didn't. I hated interviewing. I did a lot. On that study I did mainly interviews of GPs… But I can remember being out in the depths of Essex, in the dark and fog after sitting in a GP surgery, waiting for somebody to finish, and then interviewing them. I did a lot of that, yes – the GPs, and the training. I used to go out with interviewers but I never liked that knocking on doors business much.

Then when we got all the stuff in, I supervised all the coding of it. We recruited coders, and they sat in a big room and then we started producing tables and as she wrote it, I checked. I used to run all the tables on the counter-sorter, and then as she wrote it, I had to check it all. (pp. 19-20)

[In the Medicine Takers project] to what extent were people actually able to voice their own feelings?

Oh yes, well, what you did then, obviously all the interviews were on paper, and you asked questions, but then you always had quite a lot – is the questionnaire in the back? - where people were given an opportunity to say what they thought about something, And we used to analyse those and used them, I think, to cheer up the text. (p. 26)

Did this, again, include a chance for people to speak their feelings?

Yes. But, I mean, in the course of the interviews, they went into the deepest things actually. Yes, always ask, I mean, at certain points you'd ask people what they felt about it. I never could – we could come on to that, I never actually got very excited about it, myself. I'm much more interested in actions – what actions people take.

Well, go on, say a bit more about this!

Well, because I spent quite a lot of my time, and we used to spend a lot of money in the office, transcribing these open bits of the interviews, and then we spent a lot of money on coders who would - the researchers' job was, they would print out a lot of – well, copy probably, in those days – a lot of, you'd say: "Let me have the answers to this question, this open question". Then you'd get a whole list of them, and then you'd look at them, and you'd decide which ones probably you would want to use to illustrate your text. But then you'd also try to code them, you'd classify them so that you could say, "In answer to that question so many people said der...der...der", so you'd spend a lot of time doing that. And that was all part of the report of the work that we did. It was seen to be very very important.

But it never added anything for me. I think an awful lot of – probably like now – one justifies one's actions, and, of course, your feelings and everything drive your actions, but in the end what I am really interested in is – it was so rich, this data about what people had actually done, and the patterns that came out of it., astonishing. Which we knew, but to have it actually come out in front of you, differences between women with different educational levels and things like that, that was what really interested me, and I never could really get excited about the other stuff, to be honest. (pp. 37-8)

But earlier than that we'd been trying - the whole technological revolution happened, and so the whole thing about questionnaires became transformed because, you could - I think we did "optical mark reading." Where you had a paper questionnaire, but when a 4 was ringed by an interviewer, on a questionnaire, the computer just read it, but the computer couldn't do anything with all this other stuff, you see. So we must have also had budget. I've never been at work when there haven't been terrible budget pressures, but we must have had budget pressures because I can remember being quite active in the movement to get rid of these armies of people we had doing coding, because actually the computer did probably 95% of it. Then people started questioning, "Well, why do we want all this other stuff anyway?" I mean, it was radical. It was terrible, because people got made redundant, or didn't get replaced when they left. So it dwindled, but it dwindled rather after – I never fell in love with it! (p.39)

Then, of course, the question about cohabitation was taken up by the continuous surveys and became part of our way we describe families now. So that was very exciting. And being able to do the same for pregnancy, you know, how many people had actually had miscarriages. I

mean, nobody ever asked people. They were probably in people's obstetric histories, but how that work and then how it all related to women's education, to their work…

Another great colleague and friend of mine, Jean Martin, went on to do the definitive study of women's employment, really coming out of what we'd found on family formation, you know, the whole thing about women's drift. Because that took a longitudinal drift down in financial and status terms when they've had children. We began to document all that in this longitudinal history method that we'd come up with. So it was very very exciting from that point of view. And the thing nobody had ever ever asked women before whether they'd had abortions. We knew they were under-reported, but nevertheless - and we'd never asked women when they'd first had sexual intercourse. It had never been asked in Britain before. So it was very very exciting from that point of view. Lots of people were interested in it. And I think it's another aspect of - I've spent a lot of time in my life thinking about health inequalities, but actually a lot of it stems from what happens to women early in their life, if they have – and we asked them whether their pregnancy was wanted or not, and stuff like that. It was amazing. Very very interesting. (pp. 39-40)

8: Whether Researchers Should Push for Policy Changes or Not

Well, that's a very interesting question because, of course, in the rest of my life, or most of the rest of it, which was in government, it was slightly more - you tended not to get into – well, you did refer to the policy implications, but that really wasn't the job. So it was interesting that that's the angle that Ann [Cartwright] would have come from, and actually, [Michael] Young and [Peter] Willmott to an extent. They wanted to say, “This is what's wonderful about the East End”, or “This is what's wonderful about moving on”, and really let people draw their own conclusions from it. I think Ann, very much Ann's focus was, “Let's look at this. Let's look at it in a very different way. Let's listen, let's put the main focus on what people say they do and what they think about it – the important thing’s not what doctors or pharmacists [say].” That was the whole ethos, I think. It was to let the people speak.

I wasn't that sophisticated, at that point, to argue. Obviously I thought about it, because I was thinking about it all the time, but I didn't really see it. It certainly wasn't part of the remit. But that's when I got to know the Department of Health very well, I used to go to endless meetings with them, so I absolutely understood what was in the back of their minds. There was probably some explicit document about it as well. (p. 25)

9: On Varieties of Statistician

[In 1971 Karen went to work with Walter Holland in the Department of Community Medicine at St Thomas's.]

Well, part of the reason I left in the end was because I went off with one of his medics, but anyway, Walter is still another really good friend of mine. Anyway, I did a lot of teaching, which I didn't really enjoy. Medical students were really really difficult to teach, but I did do teaching - the King's Fund used to run courses - on community medicine for people doing senior hospital management courses, their training programme, and I met some amazing people through that, and I used to enjoy that kind of teaching. (p. 34)

But most of my job while I was [at the School of Hygiene], which was only a short time, but a time of enormous learning for me, I used to be the resident social scientist on the projects, However modern and forward-looking this place was, it was based very much on the, "the doctors are superior" model. So the doctors were always the project leaders. Of course, they often didn't know how to do research very well, and then they were supported by a statistician, an economist, a social scientist, or whatever, so it was very conflictual. I found that very very difficult, having come from somewhere where I ran my own projects really… Amazing people from all over the world came to work there, and I got very friendly with them, and it was fantastic… And he was very like Ann [Cartwright], very rigid, everything had to be done perfectly, which is nothing wrong with it actually, so it was quite disciplined, but we did have a lot of fun. (pp. 34}

What were the most interesting projects while you were there?

I learned a lot from that about screening, and I think I wrote a chapter for Walter, on screening, which is a very interesting topic actually, from the sociological point of view. Because it's about medical power in terms of telling you what you should do, but also this terrible decision-making about risk. It was all really interesting, and I did a lot of reading around these subjects.

But I never established a project of my own there. I got involved in lots of people's projects and the teaching, and the general sort of life, but basically, after I went off to live

with Mike, I just decided that (a) it wasn't for me, this place. I didn't really want to be an academic. It's back to that thing about, is life really all about writing papers, or exam questions? It's never really turned me on. And then this job came up at the Government Social Survey, and I thought, "Well, I'll apply for that".

[Then] I thought, "I need not to work in the same place as the person I live with" - it was awful actually - so I got that job, and I left. And that was shocking really. It was horrible at the time… I loved the people in the other job, and I loved being in that environment, where the world is coming through and there's so many ideas, and I met amazing people, and I wrote papers with amazing people. It really was good. (p. 34-5)

I knew people there [at the Office of Population Censuses and Surveys], because I'd always been active in these societies, I did know people there – a few people. So that was good. I had a few people. But it was, again, an amazing friendly place, full of really clever people, whacky people, some of them! And another hotbed of internal politics…

The Civil Service is very interesting. People come into it generally as new graduates and then you work your way up. I came in at the next level, and so I was supposed to just be able to do things, and they didn't trust that I could do it. So they tested me on this, well, it wasn't inconsequential actually, but it was for a very important customer…

So it, from that point of view, was fantastic, because I was connected up with the whole new world which really resonated with all that stuff about self-medication, how people take life and decisions about their fertility and their relationships into their own hands, and don't do the legal thing, and that all went back to this thing that I'd learnt at university how the law follows what people do, rather than the other way round. It all began to come together. (pp. 35-7)

Was it the international ones that decided only to interview women?

Yes.

So you didn't have a choice?

That would have been another whole step forward, to interview men. Oh, my God! No, that would have been – no, this was bad enough! But you know, basically they bought into it. I can't remember the name of the guy in America who was in charge of the American one, you

know, it was fine. It was fine, and it was the most amazing thing. And we got an incredibly high response rate. I mean, the interviewers loved this interview. They were nearly all women – I think they were all women in those days – they just loved it. (p. 37)

What we were trying to do was to routinise, I suppose, the collection and the presentation of the basic stats., and to use our professional energy on writing about them – analysing, and writing about them. So I was the person who then decided that it wasn't enough just to have an article every quarter in *Population Trends*, that we would start up *Health Statistics Quarterly*, and that we would then fill that up. So we did that. (p. 52)

So when I moved to Med. Stats… That was another silo. The office was a merger of the Census Department, the Registration and its statistics, the Registrar General and the Social Survey, and they never really had much interchange of staff, and they weren't interested in what the others did.

So we were all sort of second class citizens, and we were all Grade 6's for years. But anyway, so I moved there, and there were all these people working on those death statistics, pages and pages and pages of tables, and putting something out weekly, something out monthly, something out quarterly, something out annually, on it went, it was a mish-mash of historical accident. And I think that was my remit, was to try to sort it all out, so that's what I tried to do. I tried to rationalise it. We had huge projects of computerisation which, trying to computerise the coding of cause of death, for example, which went on for years and years, so it was very interesting because there was this other group of very committed people, who were mainly statisticians rather than survey people. So they were all much more mathematical, all much more nerdy, mostly men, as opposed to the Survey had been probably 60% women. So very very challenging from that point of view. (p. 48-9)

I don't think you can do really good analysis unless you really understand how your data were collected, and I don't think you can collect good data, you can't design collection things – the tools – unless you understand analysis. So you need both. (p. 60)

10: Commercialisation

There was this General Practice system that was run by a couple of GPs who got money from

drug companies, and all of a sudden it went bust. We used to talk to these people a lot, because they were involved in our GP Study, but anyway, overnight, I was asked, would I take this over? And my statistician who did hospital statistics, I said to him, "Are you interested in this? He said, "Yes!" And he went and picked up the whole thing in a white van, one weekend. It, literally, was boxes.

So that was another incredible thing because in the end it was taken away from us. We got it going again, and tried to get a new policy about how other people could use it – because that was our job, really, was to make data sets that other people could use – and then it got sent off because the Department of Health kind of took it over, but didn't have anybody to take it over, except me, I think that was the thing. Then it got sent to the pharmaceutical people, and it's still going, but it's never got out of the grip of the pharmaceutical industries who don't want it used, they want money for it, which is anathema, of course, to me! (p. 53)

11: Challenging Civil Service Resistance to Change

So what about this opposition, how serious was that? Was it just individuals who alone had their own particular way of working, didn't want to drop it, or was there a more sort of concerted kind of resistance to these changes?

Well, people always resist change, except the few silly people like me, who quite like it! Well, even I, in some circumstances would. No. But again, it's about getting people involved in helping to work out how to do things better. And to me, it's a kind of extension of what I call "professionalisation" - professionalism really. To me, professionalism is all about always looking for a better way to do things, and improve ways to do things. And, of course, we'd all been through a technological revolution. People had had to adapt to that. But first of all, in the office there was this separation between people who worked on continuous surveys, where actually, it was very narrow and very repetitive, and, of course, they were terrified of being sent out into the wide world where they might get told, "Tomorrow, you're going to do family formation." Well, they wouldn't have been able to do it, of course – but it was a, but it was a terrible source of inflexibility. And again, people who were used to running projects, maybe two years and then you start another one, didn't want to go and work in this area, which actually was very exciting because you had so much data. I mean, now I think it's probably very different because large-scale surveys are now the thing.' (pp. 46-7)

In the Civil Service you always got terrible budget pressures. You nearly always get cut. If you get money, it's for something special and ring-fenced. So, they would be very very unsupportive, I think, about, about any kind of financial rationalisation. Of course, because they were intimately knowledgeable about their bits of the business – and don't forget, these places are all like silos, there'd be the old Survey people, and the old Economics Statistics people, it was terrible. They argued among themselves, and [Tim Holt as Director] couldn't bring them together. My job was to get the the first White Paper on Statistical Independence, off the ground, and they weren't interested in it, they weren't interested in the idea of national statistics or the Government Statistical Service. They just wanted to carry on, the powerful ones just wanted to carry on being the CSO – Central Statistical Office. (p. 54)

It sounds very like your experience actually in the medical field, where you wanted to systematise it. But it's on a larger scale, you mean.

Much larger scale, yes. So, how do you create an office culture? How do you create a sense of coherent professionalism among all these strands of people who have come from different bits of government and you're now wanting them to work together, and the government is asking you to be a National {Statistical Office]. This was my boss's challenge, to be the National Statistician, and to have a common set of a code of practice, and a common culture about statistics all over government, just not in the office – and that was part of my job, to help him with the rest of the Government Statistical Service. So it was very very interesting, learning about how people were coming at this from different points of view, how people in policy departments were under very very different pressures from what we were. They were frequently told they couldn't do things, which was against the professional code of conduct. But basically his senior people didn't really support him, they just wanted to carry on doing what they were doing, basically, and keeping their cosy relationships with the Bank of England and the Treasury, and they didn't want anybody interfering with it.

It was very very interesting. But, of course, it was a total culture shock for me because I didn't know these people very well at all, and I'd never worked in a Policy Department. Many of them had come from Policy Departments and it was quite difficult. But anyway, we got the White Paper. And [Tim] was a very unconvincing – Tim was a lovely man, but he wasn't, he didn't inspire energy and enthusiasm and things in people at all, actually. He was quiet and didn't like promotion, and sometimes in these jobs you have to

promote yourself in order to promote the idea, it's not enough just to go along and say good things, you've got to be able to sell it. Live it and sell it. (pp. 55-6)

And the way that you persuaded people was, basically, you've talked about bringing them together but was it also talking to them individually?

I'm not that keen on that. That is most – most people's strategy, for example, about difficult meetings, to go and have lunch with each of the awkward customers, and try to get them on side one by one, so that when it comes the meeting, you know you'll get your way. Well, it's not my way. I mean, (a) I don't have time. Look, I only learned how to work when I became a mother, because I could only then work from 9.30 to 5, and believe me, when you can only work from 9.30 to 5, you know how to work, and that's how I learned to work. And I don't like working in the evenings – I never have! No, so I don't want to waste my time getting them all like that – so that's not how I did it. No.

How do I do it? Well, I spend quite a lot of time thinking about the pros and cons of things, okay? I'm very good at making decisions, but I don't make them off the cuff, I spend quite a lot of time, what I call "in gestation" of things. So I'd rather go to a meeting and it be quite difficult because people will be arguing among themselves, but then, hopefully, at the end of the meeting you might say, "Well, I think, you know, that we should, on the basis of what I've heard, do this", and everybody will have heard everybody's arguments. When you take them all out to lunch, they don't hear all the arguments. So that's how I tried to do it. And also not coming up with a solution I think is very good. Getting groups of people to come up with, together, a set of goals, then they can't say they don't believe in them. If it's just yours, it doesn't work. So you can work with people so that you come up with a set of goals and work out which are the ones that are most important – that usually emerges.

Then another technique I use all the time, which I try to tell people in schools and universities to do, is set a group of people the task of finding the solution. Because, actually, they've got better ideas than you have, and they usually know how the works go better than you do, and they usually come up with a good way to go forward. So that's how I do it – on the whole. Sometimes you have to put your foot down, but I don't, if people can own the solution…

I spent a huge amount of time with junior staff. I used to go round a lot and just land up and go round and talk to the people actually doing the work, and I learned a lot that way, and then you really learn what's not working. But a lot of our technological steps forward

were all invented, or thought of, by people on the ground. They know, at the end of the day, how inefficient things they're doing are. They're the people who really know that what a waste of time it is licking all these envelopes. So if you let them do it, it works – in my experience. It takes time sometimes. (pp. 58-9)

They had their survey data, and they only [used that], because most people had only ever worked there. It was incredible, that office, because it was a merger. They didn't know about what went on upstairs in population statistics or health, medical statistics, they didn't know. People are very very insular at work, they like to work on their own thing – the thing they're comfortable with. I'm sure it happens everywhere.

So it's breaking people out of that actually, that I'm interested in – getting people to try new things. It's terribly important, in my view, for organisations, because it's only the people who can, who have moved around. It took me a long time to move out of my comfort zone too, but I was shaken out of it actually, by things happening in my life that meant I changed jobs. That was a terrible shake-up actually. But people get stuck in a groove and think they can't do anything else. That's one of the things that I've really enjoyed, was helping people through the process of finding out that, actually, their skills were absolutely transferable, and that they would blossom in a new environment. (p. 47)